



STATUS REPORT

Eswatini: status report

Edition of 2026-08-17 · 65 systems and instruments tracked, 9 of them not held

Compiled 2026-08-14 from the Data Landscapers source base, from [outputs/reports/SWZ/ledger.csv](#) (65 systems and instruments, 9 of them **Not held**). Each section opens with its ledger; specific events are covered in the monthly updates. Figures are dated because most are time-varying.

Status values. *Implemented* — in operation or in force. *Piloting* — running with a limited user group or in a controlled environment. *In development* — build or drafting under way, not yet operating. *Planned* — announced or provided for, no build or draft on record. *Enacted* — an instrument passed into law; pair with a qualifying clause for its in-force date. *Under review* — a law or policy currently being reconsidered. *Discontinued* — closed or superseded. *Not held* — the base carries no reliable statement of status; these are the gaps to fill and are listed again at the end.

Summary of position

Eswatini's digital agenda is well financed and thinly founded. The [Digital Eswatini Project secured more than E1.06bn of World Bank financing](#) for a 2027 rollout, and the citizen application it funds is live. What sits beneath it is not: the [national identity card does not meet the criteria for digital identification](#), the population register held is a [1984 paper register](#), and the [Digital Landscape Assessment found nine of twenty-one ministries keeping no regular backups](#).

The data-protection institution moved from paper to practice in the period: the Act has been in force since 2022, and the authority [opened its first major investigation in June 2026, into a ministry](#) that published unblurred national identity documents. Payments are the most deliberately built layer — an interoperability-first switch, an e-KYC registry and a FinTech Strategy — against [more than 90% of person-to-business payments still made in cash](#).

Infrastructure

Connectivity

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	STATUS ↗ source	MILESTONE
Mbabane smart-city deployment	IN DEVELOPMENT ↗	5G network, 59 AI-enabled cameras and public Wi-Fi being fitted in the capital
Minimum internet service standard	PLANNED ↗	ESCCOM proposed raising the minimum from 2 Mbps to 10 Mbps in Notice 08/2026
National fibre-optic backbone	IN DEVELOPMENT ↗	International capacity raised from 47 to 72 Gbps, above target

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	STATUS ↗ source	MILESTONE
Public-institution connectivity programme	IN DEVELOPMENT ↗	1,031 institutions targeted under the Digital Eswatini Project
Statutory complaint adjudication by ESCCOM	IMPLEMENTED ↗	Free adjudication under the Eswatini Communications Commission Act 2013, with windows of one month for post and courier, three for broadcasting and six for telecommunications

Data Storage

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	STATUS ↗ source	MILESTONE
National Data Centre	IMPLEMENTED ↗	Government assessment finds ministries depend heavily on it with no internal fallback

Energy

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	STATUS ↗ source	MILESTONE
Power supply to the National Data Centre	PLANNED ↗	ICT minister met an Abu Dhabi clean-energy firm to discuss dedicated supply; nothing signed

Technical Capacity

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	STATUS ↗ source	MILESTONE
Compute or high-performance computing capacity	NOT HELD	The National Data Centre states high-performance computing as an objective but discloses no capacity

Cybersecurity

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	STATUS ↗ source	MILESTONE
National cybersecurity awareness programme	IMPLEMENTED ↗	Cybersecurity Awareness Month opened by the prime minister
SADC regional cybersecurity framework	ENACTED ↗	Finalised and approved by the SADC Committee of Central Bank Governors subcommittee at Ezulwini

Coverage is not the constraint: the ICT ministry puts mobile coverage at 95% against mobile-internet subscription of 57%, blaming data prices and paper-based public services, and data costs 3.47% of gross national income per head, above the international affordability threshold. The regulator proposed on 20 July 2026 raising the minimum service standard from 2 Mbps to 10 Mbps; the 2 Mbps standard remains in force.

International capacity rose from 47 to 72 Gbps, above target, on a World Bank-supported fibre rollout; the Digital Eswatini Project is to connect 1,031 public institutions — 859 schools, 134 health facilities and 38 tinkhundla centres; and a government Starlink gateway was commissioned in April 2026 to reduce dependence on cross-border fibre.

The state's own estate is the weak point, on the government's own evidence. The Digital Landscape Assessment endorsed on 21 May 2026 found nine of twenty-one ministries keeping no regular backups, eleven with no ICT maintenance contract, and the finance ministry running mainframe software past end of life. Only 31 of 419 government services are online, and eighteen ICT professionals support the whole assessed estate. The same report names near-universal dependence on one hosting provider as a structural concentration risk.

That provider is the National Data Centre, on which the base holds [an operator's prospectus disclosing no capacity, tenant, uptime tier or utilisation](#). Its power supply was [still being sourced in February 2026](#), five years on.

Digital public infrastructure

Digital Identity and CRVS

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	STATUS ↗ source	MILESTONE
Digital identity	PLANNED ↗	Electronic IDs planned under the Digital Eswatini Project for a 2027 rollout
National e-KYC registry	IN DEVELOPMENT ↗	Central bank standing it up to digitise identity verification
National identity card	IMPLEMENTED, NOT A DIGITAL IDENTITY ↗	Production resumed 22 February 2026 after suspension in late September 2025

Digital Payments and Fintech

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	STATUS ↗ source	MILESTONE
Comparative benchmark of bank charges	PLANNED ↗	Portfolio committee recommended the central bank report within 30 days of adoption
Eswatini Payment Switch	IMPLEMENTED ↗	Fast Payments launched at Ezulwini, phase one of three
Migration of Common Monetary Area low-value flows to TCIB	IN DEVELOPMENT ↗	Reported as under way; no timetable, volume, value or mandating instrument given
National FinTech Strategy 2025-2030	IMPLEMENTED ↗	Launched by the central bank governor and the finance minister
PAPSS accession	PLANNED ↗	Central bank governor discussed leveraging Egyptian experience to accelerate accession
Post offices as government payment points	IMPLEMENTED ↗	35 post offices opened for government-service payments

Registries (population, land, address, etc.)

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	STATUS ↗ source	MILESTONE
National population register	IMPLEMENTED ↗	Compulsory civil register commenced 6 January 1984 under the Births, Marriages and Deaths Registration Act 1983 (Act 5 of 1983), administered by a Registrar of Births, Marriages and Deaths in the Ministry of Home Affairs
Proposed DNA requirement for birth certificates	PLANNED ↗	Costed at about E126m a year, roughly 46% of the Home Affairs budget

Sectoral management information systems (HMIS, EMIS, etc.)

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	STATUS ↗ source	MILESTONE
Community health services digitisation	IMPLEMENTED ↗	Transition from paper to digital records documented
Umelusi, TruMD and Content Creator Hub platforms	IMPLEMENTED ↗	Three platforms launched with MTN Eswatini for agriculture, health and the creative economy

Other GovTech and e-Gov

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	STATUS ↗ source	MILESTONE
Eswatini Revenue Service TaxPal	IMPLEMENTED ↗	Launched alongside Government In Your Hand for tax accounts and clearance certificates
Google Cloud EMEA memorandum	ENACTED ↗	Attorney-General confirmed Cabinet and legal consultation preceded signature
Government In Your Hand citizen application	IMPLEMENTED ↗	Prime minister told Parliament it must be watertight and that he does not support outsourcing data to global technology companies
National e-Government Strategy	IN DEVELOPMENT ↗	Digital Landscape Assessment received and endorsed to found the strategy

Rural digital data capture

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	STATUS ↗ source	MILESTONE
USSD access to public services	PLANNED ↗	Planned under the Digital Eswatini Project so citizens without smartphones can transact

Digitalisation of sub-national government

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	STATUS ↗ source	MILESTONE
Tinkhundla centre connectivity	PLANNED ↗	38 tinkhundla centres included in the Digital Eswatini connectivity target

National statistics

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	STATUS ↗ source	MILESTONE
FinScope Consumer Survey	IN DEVELOPMENT ↗	2026 round launched, replacing a 2018 measurement
State of Communications Sector Study 2025/26	IN DEVELOPMENT ↗	Tender of about E2.8m awarded by ESCCOM

Use of satellite data

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	STATUS ↗ source	MILESTONE
Government Starlink satellite gateway	IMPLEMENTED ↗	Commissioned to reach mountainous and remote areas and reduce dependence on cross-border fibre
Starlink Business reseller channel	IMPLEMENTED ↗	Paratus Group and Real Image Internet joint venture launched as authorised reseller

The payments layer is the most deliberately designed part of the stack. The [Eswatini Payment Switch launched Fast Payments at Ezulwini on 11 December 2024](#), phase one of three, connecting four commercial banks, the building society and three mobile-money operators — [built for the people banks do not reach](#). Open banking and card, point-of-sale and ATM switching are still to come; three of eight participants were live on launch day and no source held confirms whether the rest followed. The [National FinTech Strategy 2025-2030 targets 500,000 e-KYC users and 80% interoperability by 2028](#), and the [central bank is standing up the e-KYC registry](#) both depend on.

What has not moved is behaviour: [more than 90% of person-to-business payments were still cash-based in August 2025](#). Two July 2026 developments bear on why. The central bank [launched the FinScope 2026 survey](#), its governor stating that the [87% access rate recorded in 2018 measured access and not use](#); and a parliamentary committee [put the price of a transaction on the record](#) – a withdrawal of E4,000 attracting E79 to E89 in fees – ordering a benchmark against SACU and Common Monetary Area banks. Cross-border, Eswatini is [not a PAPSS participant](#) and no accession date is stated, while low-value Common Monetary Area flows move onto a regional scheme with no timetable or mandating instrument on file.

Identity is the foundation the rest is built without. The [national identity card does not meet the criteria for digital identification](#), and [production of even that card was suspended in late September 2025 and resumed on 22 February 2026](#), disrupting banking, employment and travel for months. Electronic IDs are [planned for the 2027 rollout](#). The [Births, Marriages and Deaths Registration Act 1983](#) has run a compulsory civil register since 6 January 1984, not shown to be digitised. A proposal to [require DNA testing before issuing birth certificates](#) would cost about 46% of the Home Affairs budget.

The citizen-facing layer shipped ahead of that foundation. [Government In Your Hand](#) launched in May 2025; six weeks later a reporter [could locate public data on it](#), which the e-government services director conceded rather than [denied](#), citing the absence of a proper digital ID and digital signatures.

Governance and regulation

Legislation and regulation

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	STATUS ↗ source	MILESTONE
Cybersecurity, critical infrastructure, e-commerce and AI legislation	PLANNED ↗	Named as forthcoming alongside the Mbabane smart-city deployment
Online Media Publishing Guidelines 2026	IN DEVELOPMENT ↗	Ministry stated development is complete

Strategies, plans and policies

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	STATUS ↗ source	MILESTONE
National Data Governance Policy	IN DEVELOPMENT ↗	ICT minister told the Senate the policy is targeted for completion before end-2026, with government undecided between a standalone data-governance law and amendments to existing legislation

Regional collaboration

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	STATUS ↗ source	MILESTONE
SADC adequacy model for cross-border data transfers	IMPLEMENTED ↗	Transfers within SADC permitted under conditions by the Data Protection Act 2022

Standards

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	STATUS ↗ source	MILESTONE
Division of the data-protection mandate	IMPLEMENTED ↗	ICT ministry stated on the record that implementation, enforcement and oversight are vested in ESCCOM, not itself

Data protection

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	STATUS ↗ source	MILESTONE
Advisory guidelines on processing personal health data	IN DEVELOPMENT ↗	Validation workshops opened at Ezulwini
Biometric gate passes in schools	IMPLEMENTED, CONTESTED ↗	Deployed by some public schools without education ministry approval, at about E200 per pupil
Data Protection Act 2022	IMPLEMENTED ↗	Gazetted and effective 4 March 2022
Eswatini Data Protection Authority	IMPLEMENTED ↗	Opened its first major investigation, into the Ministry of Home Affairs
Home Affairs publication of unblurred national identity documents	IMPLEMENTED ↗	Investigation opened; the ministry missed the 72-hour breach-notification duty
United States bilateral health agreement and its data-sharing agreement	NOT HELD	—

Public debate and participation in policymaking

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	STATUS ↗ source	MILESTONE
Public account of the Google memorandum	IMPLEMENTED ↗	Prime minister first dismissed the memorandum, then acknowledged in writing that Cabinet had approved it

EU activities

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	STATUS ↗ source	MILESTONE
European Union digital cooperation with Eswatini	NOT HELD	No source on file naming a European instrument, though European partners support the data policy through a regional channel

Open data

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	STATUS ↗ source	MILESTONE
Open government data portal	NOT HELD	No portal or open-data instrument on file; the data governance policy text is not published

The [Data Protection Act 2022 took effect on 4 March 2022](#), with fines to E5,000,000 or 2% of annual turnover and a SADC-adequacy model for cross-border transfers. The World Bank recorded the [office as not yet operationalised in July 2025](#), three years on.

The authority [ran a campaign with a 31 March 2026 registration deadline for organisations collecting personal data](#), then [opened an investigation into the Ministry of Home Affairs for publishing unblurred national identity documents](#), which missed the 72-hour notification duty. In July it moved to sectoral rule-making, [beginning](#)

[validation of advisory guidelines on processing personal health data](#), to be published as a regulatory instrument under the Act. Eswatini's bilateral health agreement with the United States, and the data-sharing agreement attached to it, are [withheld and in litigation](#) since 2 April 2026.

The National Data Governance Policy followed the same order: procured through a tender in July 2025, a first workshop in April 2026, and [validated on 27 July 2026 with a stated cycle of 2027 to 2031](#) — text unpublished. In the Senate on 10 August 2026, a senator warned the country remained exposed for lack of the policy; [the ICT minister said she was targeting completion before end-2026 and that government had yet to decide between a standalone data-governance law and amendments to existing legislation](#).

The same body regulates communications and polices data protection, and the sponsoring ministry [confirmed on the record on 4 August 2026 that implementation, enforcement and oversight do not fall within its mandate](#) but are vested in ESCCOM. In the same answer it said it had completed the Online Media Publishing Guidelines 2026, introducing publisher registration bound to accuracy, privacy protection, child safeguarding and the responsible use of AI. Neither their text nor a commencement date is public.

Artificial intelligence and the technology sector

AI

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	STATUS ↗ source	MILESTONE
ESCCOM guidance on AI and deepfakes in broadcasting	IMPLEMENTED ↗	Regulator urged broadcasters to manage AI ethically and transparently
National 4IR Strategy	IMPLEMENTED ↗	Framed the prime minister's address to the Global Dialogue on AI Governance in Geneva
Regional AI health partnership	PLANNED ↗	Memorandum signed in Eswatini between a regional health body and a private firm
National AI strategy	NOT HELD	Two instruments now carry AI rules and neither is an AI instrument; no strategy or statute on file

ICT Industry

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	STATUS ↗ source	MILESTONE
Letshego Eswatini digital bank	IN DEVELOPMENT ↗	Provisional banking licence granted; transition to a full digital bank under way

Innovation ecosystem

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	STATUS ↗ source	MILESTONE
Eswatini-Taiwan digital cooperation	PLANNED ↗	Digital transformation named a priority area at a leaders' meeting in Taipei

US / hyperscaler activities

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	STATUS ↗ source	MILESTONE
Google partnership with Eswatini	ENACTED ↗	Eswatini represented at the Google Cloud Summit Africa 2026, with Government In Your Hand showcased

China activities

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	STATUS ↗ source	MILESTONE
Chinese digital investment in Eswatini	NOT HELD	No source on file; Eswatini has no diplomatic relations with China

India activities

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	STATUS ↗ source	MILESTONE
Indian digital cooperation with Eswatini	NOT HELD	A US\$10m India Exim Bank line of credit appears in the tracked finance records; no source describing an Indian digital programme is held

Gulf/UAE activities

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	STATUS ↗ source	MILESTONE
She Powers Africa Digital Academy	IMPLEMENTED ↗	Launched virtually under an Eswatini-UAE memorandum signed at the 2025 UN General Assembly

No national AI strategy or statute is held. What exists instead are two instruments that reach AI without being AI instruments: [ESCCOM's November 2025 guidance urging broadcasters to manage AI ethically and transparently](#) against deepfakes, and the [Online Media Publishing Guidelines 2026](#), whose AI provisions ride into force on a [publisher-registration regime](#). An AI-use rule enforced by a registration requirement is bounded by that requirement's reach.

The stated posture is skills and governance first. The prime minister told the [Global Dialogue on AI Governance in Geneva in July 2026](#) that [small and developing nations should not become mere consumers of technologies developed elsewhere](#), urging investment in local innovation, research, digital literacy and computing infrastructure, framed around the National 4IR Strategy.

Foreign partnerships carry the sector. The [Google Cloud EMEA memorandum was established as a cloud-services and e-government framework rather than a monetisation deal](#) after a cabinet controversy; no value or term has been published. A [UAE-delivered women's digital academy took its first cohort of 50 in July 2026](#), designed, staffed and certified abroad, and [digital transformation was named a priority of the Taiwan relationship in August 2026](#) with nothing signed or costed. Domestically, [Letshego holds a provisional licence to become a full digital bank](#).

Inclusion and capacity

Digital divides

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	STATUS ↗ source	MILESTONE
Community innovation hubs	IN DEVELOPMENT ↗	Second hub opened at Macetjeni in the Lubombo Region

Literacy

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	STATUS ↗ source	MILESTONE
Published guidance on digital workplace transformation	IMPLEMENTED ↗	Book by a domestic ICT practitioner

Training and skills

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	STATUS ↗ source	MILESTONE
AI, robotics and cybersecurity training at innovation hubs	PLANNED ↗	Announced at the Macetjeni hub handover as the next phase beyond basic digital literacy
Digital Eswatini change agents	IMPLEMENTED ↗	Cross-ministry change agents in training for the 2027 rollout

Research institutions

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	STATUS ↗ source	MILESTONE
Public research programme in digital or data science	NOT HELD ↗	No research programme, centre mandate or published output on file

Access is improving on ownership and unresolved on use: Global Findex 2025, cited in an August 2025 account, [puts account ownership at 63%, up from below 50% a decade earlier, led by mobile money.](#)

Capacity is where the ambition is largest relative to the base. The ICT minister set a target of [300,000 digitally skilled citizens in a population of about 1.2m](#). Delivery so far is a [second community innovation hub, opened at Macetjeni on 6 August 2026](#) after Pigg's Peak, with a third planned, and [AI, robotics, coding and cybersecurity courses announced there](#) with no start date, provider or cohort size given. No public research programme in digital or data science is held.

Finance

New investments

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	STATUS ↗ source	MILESTONE
Digital Eswatini Project	IMPLEMENTED ↗	More than E1.06bn of World Bank financing approved, reported at US\$65m

MoUs and other agreements

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	STATUS ↗ source	MILESTONE
Global South Utilities discussions on data-centre power	PLANNED ↗	Met at the World Government Summit; nothing signed

Domestic budget appropriations and expenditure

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	STATUS ↗ source	MILESTONE
Domestic budget appropriation for digital transformation	NOT HELD	No estimates volume or appropriation line on file for the ICT ministry, ESCCOM or RSTP

Financing is concentrated and overwhelmingly external. The [Digital Eswatini Project](#) was approved at more than E1.06bn, E648m for broadband and E450m for the citizen application, funded by the World Bank. [Beyond that loan, tracked non-state digital finance stands at US\\$55m across four deals for 2020 to 2026, on the wiki's own compilation as of 6 August 2026 – not a published figure.](#) No domestic appropriation line for the ICT ministry, the regulator or the science park is held, so the base cannot say what the state itself puts in against what it borrows.

Gaps to fill

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	WHAT WOULD SETTLE IT	LAST PROBED
Compute or high-performance computing capacity	A capacity disclosure for the National Data Centre - rack count, megawatts, uptime tier or utilisation - or a separate compute facility specification.	2026-08-09
Open government data portal	A national open-data portal, the published National Data Governance Policy text, or an access-to-information instrument.	2026-08-09
European Union digital cooperation with Eswatini	A named EU or European Investment Bank instrument, financing or programme covering Eswatini digital work.	2026-08-09
National AI strategy	A national AI strategy or statute, or a ministerial statement giving its drafting stage and expected adoption date.	2026-08-09
Chinese digital investment in Eswatini	Any Chinese financing, contract or memorandum covering Eswatini digital infrastructure.	2026-08-09
Indian digital cooperation with Eswatini	The India Exim Bank line-of-credit agreement or a programme document describing what it funds.	2026-08-09
Public research programme in digital or data science	A university research centre mandate, a public research programme, or published research output in digital or data science.	2026-08-09
Domestic budget appropriation for digital transformation	The estimates of expenditure or appropriation act showing lines for the ICT ministry, ESCCOM or the Royal Science and Technology Park.	2026-08-09
United States bilateral health agreement and its data-sharing agreement	The memorandum of understanding and the related data-sharing agreement themselves, a signature date, or an Eswatini government statement naming the instrument. The text is withheld rather than unpublished, and is in litigation in the United States District Court for the District of Columbia	not yet probed

Eswatini's absences sit underneath its systems rather than beside them: no capacity disclosure under the data centre the whole state depends on, no AI strategy under two instruments that already regulate AI, no appropriation line under a programme financed almost entirely from outside. The base can date and value the loan precisely and cannot say what the state itself puts in.

ABOUT THIS DOCUMENT

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